spheres of influence that had gained the British the animosity of the Persian people in the first place. Indeed, the plan as advocated by Churchill of bringing the Persian capital south under British auspices seemed likely to cause even more resentment towards Britain than the 1907 Anglo-Russian Convention had done. Instead, Delhi would rather leave Persia to its own devices, interfering only as far as was necessary to secure the southern borders and protect its interests in the south should they be threatened – which was far from the case in 1921.[49]

It is perhaps no wonder, then, that the Persian government was feeling decidedly nervous in 1921. The Red Army landings at Enzeli the previous May had shown that it could not rely on British military support to protect it from Bolshevik aggression. Now, the withdrawal of Norperforce, the disinterestedness in the Anglo-Persian Agreement, and the seeming willingness of the British government to abandon north Persia to the Bolsheviks as it scuttled south, all left the Persian government feeling somewhat abandoned by Britain. It is, therefore, hardly surprising that Zia'eddin or his successors sought the financial and administrative help of America, or wanted closer relations with France, or even that they tried to enlist Swedish officers to help organise a national army.[50] Curzon may have seen this as a betrayal towards Britain, but one wonders what other choice Persia really had in 1921.

It was just this lack of options that would lead to what one would have thought was the greatest blow to Curzon's Persian policy of the entire period – the signing of a 'treaty of friendship' between Persia and Soviet Russia on 26 February 1921.[51] In Norman's opinion, at least, it was Britain's lack of commitment to Persia that had directly contributed to the creation of this treaty. In January the minister had warned that the withdrawal 'of our troops and discontinuance of financial assistance must sooner or later involve loss of our influence over [the] Persian Government, who, having nothing to hope for from us, must turn elsewhere for help'.[52] In May, he expanded further: